act as a global leader based on the size of its population or historical and moral claims.

During two centuries of British rule, Indians had no control over economic, foreign or military policies. Even during the two world wars, when thousands of Indian soldiers fought as part of the British army around the world, Indians served as cannon fodder rather than as decision makers. That experience has led to an Indian reluctance to send its troops abroad under multinational command. United Nations peacekeeping missions have been an exception to this rule. Peacekeeping under the aegis of the United Nations has a moral dimension and fulfils India's desire to play a global role in addition to demonstrating India's credentials in helping less fortunate countries. India refused to send troops for the wars in Korea (1950–53) or Vietnam (1955–75) or for the Gulf War in 1991.

Many people were surprised when during the US-led war in Iraq in 2003, the Indian parliament and cabinet actually debated an American request for the participation of Indian troops. India did not join the war in the end but that India debated such an issue was for many a first and showed the changes in how Indians, and others, view India's global role.[11]

India's reluctance to send troops outside its borders does not, however, extend to its immediate neighbourhood. India sent troops to Sri Lanka in 1987–90 to enforce a ceasefire between the government and Tamil rebel guerillas, and to Maldives in 1988 against a coup attempt. India has also fought four wars with Pakistan, including the 1971 war that resulted in the creation of Bangladesh. In the Indian view, the immediate neighbourhood is still part of the subcontinent and so is India's arena for maintaining security.

In the economic realm, India has desired self-sufficiency and autarky since Independence. Some of India's founding leaders hoped to create self-sufficient villages as envisaged in Gandhi's slogan of 'Ram Rajya' (literally 'Ram's Rule', meaning an ideal state). On the other hand, Nehru, a Fabian socialist, believed that the commanding heights of the economy should